



Qatar: A Historical Overview from Ancient Times to the Establishment of the Emirate in 1868

History of Qatar Course-HIST 121



Midterm Examination Materials - Fall 2025

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Introduction

The scientific material adopted in the midterm exam for the Qatar History course covers important topics that outline the features of this history and the major events and developments Qatar has witnessed from ancient times until the establishment of the emirate in 1868. To understand the events and developments that the country has undergone, the course will initially introduce the geography of Qatar, including the characteristics of its location, climate, population, cities, and islands, and analyze the impact of these factors on the historical events that have occurred on the Qatar Peninsula. A general overview of the types of sources relied upon by researchers to study Qatar's political, social, economic, administrative, and cultural history through the ages will also be presented. This contributes to understanding the features of ancient Qatar's history by tracing the earliest references in sources about the identity of human settlement in Qatar, its beginnings, and the locations of its settlement from the earliest times until the advent of Islam. Given the importance of the major transformations associated with the emergence and spread of Islam and its early arrival in the eastern Arabian Peninsula, the course will trace the history of Islam's spread among the tribes of Qatar. It will explain the importance of Qatar's geographical location to the economic life and activities of its inhabitants during the Islamic eras.

The course will also cover the important topic of international rivalry in the Gulf region, explaining the external powers that began to appear on the Gulf coasts at the beginning of the 16th century, including the Portuguese, Dutch, British, and Ottoman Empire, and the reasons and motives that led to their infiltration of the region. This is important for understanding the impact on Qatar and the Gulf of the



stages of British influence and control over the region and the development of Ottoman-British rivalry over Qatar, especially after the establishment of the emirate in 1868.

To understand the local conditions prevailing in the Al-Ahsa region, of which Qatar was a part before the establishment of the emirate, the course will shed light on the political conditions, especially the local powers that successively extended control and influence over it, and their impact on Qatar.

To comprehend the circumstances contributing to the establishment of the emirate in Qatar, the course will narrate, relate, and analyze the conflict between the Al Khalifa family over power in Bahrain in the 1840s, the expansion of this conflict into Qatari territories, the participation of Qatari tribes in it, and the region's involvement in widespread tribal conflicts that alarmed the British authorities over their influence and interests.



General Introduction to the Geography of Qatar

Geography plays a vital role in determining the course of history in any region. Geographical knowledge facilitates the researcher's understanding of the political, economic, and social developments occurring through the ages. Therefore, before delving into the major events that have marked its history, it is necessary to study the geography of Qatar, including its location, terrain, climate, water resources, demographics, and the role all of these factors have played in the region's historical development.

Qatar: Location and Borders

The Qatar Peninsula is located in the southwestern corner of Asia, on the eastern edge of the Arabian Peninsula, and faces the western coast of the Arabian Gulf. It is bordered to the east by the United Arab Emirates, to the south and west by the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, and to the west by the Kingdom of Bahrain. Qatar is connected by land to Saudi Arabia and shares maritime boundaries with the UAE, the Islamic Republic of Iran, and Bahrain.

Qatar's location as a peninsula extending into the heart of the Arabian Gulf has provided it with several key advantages:

1. Abundant pearl diving sites and fishing grounds.
2. A major station for commercial ships crossing the Gulf.
3. Connectivity with the outside world (Europe, Africa, Asia) due to its location in the southwestern corner of Asia.
4. A link between the eastern and western parts of the Gulf and between the Gulf with the Arabian Peninsula via a land passage, which played a significant role in shaping the region's history and served as a conduit for waves of Arab tribal migration.



5. The development of various economic and social activities, with the peninsula's location providing a vital source of livelihood and wealth for its inhabitants, through trade routes, maritime transport, pearl diving, and fishing, leading to the flourishing of coastal villages.
6. Political influence on the shape and nature of historical relations between Qatar and the surrounding areas.
7. Preservation of Qatar's Arab identity in terms of land and population and its cultural and Islamic heritage throughout history.

Area

Qatar covers an estimated area of 11,500 square kilometres, making it the second smallest country in the Gulf after Bahrain. It stretches approximately 185 km from north to south, and its width ranges from 55 km at its narrowest point to about 85 km at its widest point. Qatar's coastline extends for 560 km, and its land borders are about 60 km long.

Terrain

Most of Qatar's land consists of a flat, rocky, and sandy plain (with the highest elevation at 103 meters), interspersed with some low hills. Dunes are widespread across most of the country. The soil in coastal areas is characterized by high salinity, which discourages agricultural activities, except in the northern regions, where arable land accounts for about 1.21% of the total area.

Climate

Qatar's climate is characterized by high temperatures and high humidity throughout the year due to its tropical location and the warm waters of the Gulf surrounding it. Qatar's summer is long (from early April to October) and is hot and humid, while its winter is short (from November to March) and mild, with occasional



light and irregular rainfall accompanied by dust storms.

This explains the scarcity of surface water, especially in the interior regions, and the absence of rivers and lakes (except for some dry valleys and sabkhas). Qatar's groundwater, both shallow and deep, is divided into two major basins: the northern and southern aquifers.

Population in Qatar

Internal cohesion and solidarity have always been features of Qatar's population, serving as a strong barrier against external threats. European travellers who visited the Gulf in the 18th century, including the Danish traveller Niebuhr around 1759, noted that Qatar had three villages: Al Huwaila, Al Yousifiya, and Freiha, all located in the far north of Qatar. Lorimer's "Gazetteer of the Persian Gulf" also provided data from the late 19th and early 20th centuries about the tribes, cities, and villages in Qatar, mentioning that Qatar's population comprised both Bedouin and urban tribes.

Year	Population	Notes
1872	10,000	The first population estimate after Qatar came under Ottoman rule.
1907	27,000	British government estimates in the Gulf. About 6,000 of the population were foreigners.
1930	30,000	Slight increase due to the declining demand for natural pearls following the emergence of cultured pearls.
1949	20,000	Population decline due to migration to oil-producing Gulf countries.

Population Growth Estimates in Qatar (1872-1949)

The distribution of Qatar's population has been influenced by various factors and conditions, including maritime economic activities in the past and general geographic, economic, urban, and historical conditions in the present. Qatar is generally divided into two main zones in terms of population distribution:



Inhabited Zone: This zone extends along the eastern coast from Mesaieed in the south to Al Ruwais in the north, with Doha located centrally. It contains at least 95% of Qatar's population within an area that covers no more than 20% of the country's total area. This zone is the backbone of the economy, services, and general activities linked to the Arabian Gulf coast, with Doha alone housing more than 45% of the population.

Uninhabited Zone: This zone extends across northern, southern, and western Qatar, occupying about 80% of the country's area and having an irregular shape. Recently, the municipalities across Qatar have seen a rise in their population due to increased development rates, with a focus on redistributing the population and accompanying industrial and urban development, such as the creation of industrial cities like Ras Laffan and Mesaieed.

Islands and Cities in Qatar

Qatar is surrounded by several significant islands, including:

1. Halul Island: Located 100 km northeast of Doha, Halul Island was historically a hub for pearl divers in the Gulf and a resting station for fishermen, providing refuge during harsh weather. After the discovery of oil, the Qatari government transformed the island into a port for shipping exploration and drilling equipment. It now hosts a large facility for collecting and storing oil from offshore fields and houses one of Qatar's most important naval bases, along with coastal protection and border guard units. Additionally, Halul Island is a significant environmental and wildlife reserve, home to various species of birds, fish, and turtles.
2. Al-Ashat Island: Situated midway between Doha and Khawr al Udayd, this island is known for its rich pearl diving sites and fishing grounds.
3. Al-Bashiria Island: A small island located east of Mesaieed Port and near Al-Ashat Island.



4. Safliya Island: This island extends from east to west and is the closest to Doha, located 7 km away.
5. Al-Aaliya Island: Larger and higher than Safliya Island, Al-Aaliya is situated approximately 5 km north of it and lies opposite the Jubailat area on Qatar's eastern coast.
6. Rakan Island: Located opposite Al Ruwais village in the north, ships often navigate around this island en route to and from Qatar. It is known for receiving the highest rainfall in Qatar.
7. Abu Al-Bark Island: Situated opposite Ras Abu Al-Bark, this island consists of a group of interlinked small islands.

Major Cities:

Most of Qatar's cities are located along the eastern coast:

1. Doha: The capital city, located on the eastern coast, is Qatar's largest urban center and a crucial commercial hub. Doha Municipality is one of the oldest in Qatar, established in the 1950s. Historically, members of the Al Buainain tribe, who migrated to Al Wakrah, contributed to founding Doha. Doha is divided into nine neighborhoods, inhabited by various tribes such as Al Maadid, Al Sudan, Al Bu Kawara, Al Bin Ali, Al Amaamira, Al Dawsari, Al Baqaqla, along with communities from Bahrain, Al Huwala, and Najd.
2. Al Wakrah: The second most important city after Doha, located on the eastern coast, home to the Al Buainain tribe and other groups such as Al Huwala, Al Maadid, Al Khalifat, and Al Amaamira.
3. Al Zubara: An archaeological city in northern Qatar, famous for its historical fort and significant in the first half of the 20th century for its pearl trade. It was also a center for the Al Utub tribes and their trade.
4. Al Khor: Situated about 57 kilometres north of Doha, Al Khor is a coastal city with a harbour for fishing boats and small ships.



5. Mesaieed: An important industrial city.
6. Madinat ash Shamal: A modern city built to serve as an administrative centre for several coastal villages in the far north.
7. Dukhan: Located on Qatar's western coast, known for its oil fields.
8. Ras Laffan: The second industrial city after Mesaieed, from where natural gas is exported through its massive port.



Sources for Studying the History of Qatar

The study of history requires identifying the sources from which historians derive their documents and information, which form the essential material for their research. These sources are available in many institutions, documentation centers, archives, and libraries. Once a historian has gathered sources, they seek out references closely related to their topic to help them understand and begin writing their research. It is important here to distinguish between the terms "source" and "reference." A source contains first-hand or primary historical material for research, such as artifacts, manuscripts, documents, letters, diaries, speeches, statements, and books that describe events witnessed by the author or written close to the time of the events. On the other hand, a reference builds its scientific material by analyzing, criticizing, or summarizing sources, and is usually written by historians who are temporally distant from the events.

Types of Sources on Qatar's History

1. **Documents:** These are official and non-official documents issued by governmental or private institutions, available as papers, manuscripts, or writings useful for writing the history of Qatar. Documents can be categorized into unpublished and published documents, some in Arabic and others in foreign languages (e.g., English, Ottoman, Portuguese). Some have been translated into Arabic, such as "The Qatar Affairs 1873-1904" report by Saldanha, which summarizes important political correspondences regarding Qatar between British political residents in the Gulf, the Foreign Office and India Office in London, and the British Government in Bombay. Another



example is "The Gulf Guide" by Lorimer, in its historical and geographical sections.

2. **Books by Travellers and Explorers:** These include books and works written by travellers who reached the Arabian Peninsula and the Arabian Gulf for scientific, political, or economic reasons. These works are historically significant because their authors were eyewitnesses to the events they described, offering comprehensive and precise descriptions. Some well-known travelers whose writings are valuable include:

- The Arab navigator **Ahmed bin Majid**, author of "Three Flowers in Knowing the Seas," which contains information on Portuguese activities in the Indian Ocean and conditions in Bahrain, Oman, Hormuz, and others. He met the Portuguese traveler Vasco da Gama, who benefited from his expertise.
- The English traveler **Bertram Thomas**, who visited Qatar in 1931 and provided in his book "Journey by Camel Across the Empty Quarter" descriptions of Qatar's dunes and water wells, offering valuable information for studying Qatar's environment.

3. **Periodicals:** These include all publications issued periodically (daily, weekly, bi-monthly, monthly, or annually) such as newspapers, magazines, yearbooks, supplements, and encyclopedias. Some of the most famous Qatari periodicals include:

- **The Official Gazette:** Issued in 1961, marking the start of Qatar's relationship with periodicals, this is an important record for researchers, especially on topics related to political administration, legislation, and economic growth.



- **Al-Dohah Magazine:** Issued in 1969, rich in its cultural and intellectual follow-ups on Qatari society, offering valuable material for researchers in social and cultural history.
 - **Al-Raya Newspaper:** Issued in 1979, initially weekly before becoming daily.
 - **Gulf Times:** Issued in 1978, it is the first English-language newspaper in Qatar.
4. **Folk Heritage:** Folk heritage is an important source of social history, encompassing stories, poems, proverbs, and songs, whether related to the sea or the desert. These elements reflect different social aspects of Qatari life, portraying the characteristics and features of the Qatari personality. Historians can benefit from folk heritage in writing the social history of Qatar. Notable books in this field include "**The Elegant Gift in Qatari Etiquette and Customs**" by Yusuf Al-Khulaifi, which covers Qatari customs and traditions related to marriage, celebrations, holidays, and popular games, and "**Proverbs in the Qatari Environment**," a dictionary providing explanations of words and meanings collected from oral traditions and narratives from the elderly.
5. **Contemporary Books:** These are books written by individuals about events and eras they lived through. While not always considered complete scientific works, they provide valuable insights. Examples include:
- **Mustafa Al-Dabbagh's** "Qatar: Its Past and Present," published in 1961, which is significant because the author was the Director of Education in Qatar from 1959 to 1961 and based his work on conversations with elderly Qataris.



- **Mohammed Sharif Al-Shaibani's** "The Emirate of Qatar: Past and Present," published in 1962, which chronicles Qatar from the dawn of the emirate to the end of Sheikh Ali bin Abdullah Al-Thani's reign and includes part of the political and historical memoirs written by Sheikh Mohammed bin Ahmed Al-Thani.

From European works that contain information about the history of Qatar:

- **Charles Belgrave's** "Pirate Coast," published in 1960 in English, discusses the Gulf and its emirates, relying on the diaries of British Naval Officer **Francis Loch** during the period 1818-1820.



Key Features of Ancient Qatari History

Archaeological evidence indicates that Qatar has been inhabited since the 10th millennium BC. Exploratory expeditions in southern Zubarah revealed human settlements that existed around 7,000 years ago. Ancient Greek sources also mention Qatar; Herodotus, writing in the 5th century BC, noted that the Canaanite tribes were the first to settle in Qatar, becoming renowned for their maritime navigation and trade. Additionally, Qatar appeared on the "Map of Arabia" by the Roman geographer Ptolemy in 150 AD under the name "Katara" or "Qatara," accompanied by smaller islands scattered around it. All these islands and surrounding areas were collectively referred to as the land of Bahrain.

Numerous references to Qatar can be found in Islamic geographical writings, identifying it as a significant commercial hub along the route connecting Basra and Oman. It was described as a place on the coast between Bahrain and Oman.

Archaeological Discoveries of Prehistoric Times in Qatar

1. **Philby's Surveys in 1931:** The first prehistoric archaeological discovery in Qatar was made by the traveller and explorer John Philby. In 1931, he conducted surveys in the Rub' al Khali and the Arabian Gulf, where he found several stone tools made from flint and fossils near the Iskaq Oasis in southeast Qatar. These artefacts date back to the Miocene epoch, marking the first evidence of prehistoric artefacts in Qatar.

Following this, several archaeological missions conducted excavations across the Qatar Peninsula, including:

- The Danish mission led by Holger Kapel.
- The British mission in 1973 led by D. Carty.



- The French mission led by Texier.
- The 1976 Japanese mission.
- The local mission comprises Qatari experts and other staff from the Qatar Department of Museums and Antiquities.

2. **Danish Archaeological Expedition (1960 – 1964):** Under the supervision of Holger Kapel, the Danish expedition in 1960 uncovered 40 archaeological sites in Qatar, with cultural evidence ranging from the Palaeolithic to the Neolithic periods. Kapel and his team expanded their research between 1961 and 1964, discovering an additional 68 sites believed to date back to the Palaeolithic era. In 1967, Kapel published the "Atlas of Stone Age Cultures in Qatar," summarizing the archaeological findings in the region. To facilitate the study of Qatar's prehistoric periods, Kapel categorized them into four population groups, each corresponding to a specific historical period and characterized by distinct cultural traits, spanning from 8000 BC to 2000 BC. These groups were located in various parts of Qatar, including Al-Khor, Abrouq, Wusail, Ras Uwaynat Ali, Bir Zekreet, and Jubeib, where artifacts such as scrapers, blades, stone hammers, knives, and marble mills were found, indicating a transition from hunting to settled living and food production.

3. **Excavations by Other European Missions and Their Results:**

- **British Excavation Discoveries:** The British expedition led by researcher D. Carty discovered archaeological remains at the site of Ras Abrouq, including stone tools, charred materials, fish bones, seashells, and gazelle bones. They concluded that the inhabitants of this site relied on both marine and terrestrial hunting and maintained connections with



other Gulf regions through migration and trade. The expedition also found that Abrouq dates back to 5000 BC, during a period when Qatar had a wetter climate, resulting in abundant vegetation and wildlife. The British team also conducted excavations at the Al-Dhassah site on the western coast, 50 km south of Dukhan, uncovering a collection of stone tools and pottery shards from the Ubaid culture, similar to those found in Ur, Iraq. Due to the rarity of this type of pottery in Qatar, it is believed to have been imported.

- **French Excavation Discoveries:** The French mission carried out extensive excavations, uncovering additional artifacts belonging to the first group identified by Kapel, which date back to the Palaeolithic era. French researcher Texier confirmed D. Carty's theory that the cultural remnants of this group all date to 5000 BC. They also concluded that these remains are similar to those found in other Gulf regions, such as Kuwait, Saudi Arabia, Bahrain, Oman, and the United Arab Emirates.
- **Post-Independence Excavations in Qatar:** Excavations following Qatar's independence in 1971 revealed direct connections between the Qatar Peninsula and Mesopotamia, the Indus Valley, and India. These findings highlighted Qatar's significant role in the culture and civilization of the Gulf, serving as a link between the Dilmun civilization (which existed in Bahrain and eastern Arabia), the Magan civilization in Oman, and the Sumerian civilization during the third millennium BC.

These European archaeological missions revealed evidence of early settlement in Qatar and the Gulf region during prehistoric times.

During the Greco-Roman period, Qatar was an important stop on the maritime trade route connecting Europe and India. The Greco-Roman influence in the Qatar



Peninsula is evident from the discovery of building stones and household items that match those found in Greece during that era. Additionally, the layout of houses found in Qatar is similar to those in Greece. At that time, Qatar was a key centre for exporting dried fish to Greece. The Arabian Gulf also held a significant position in global trade during the Sassanid period, connecting the East and West. Shipments of copper, coal, sandalwood, and teak from the East were exchanged for carmine dyes, clothing, pearls, dates, gold, and silver from the West. During this period, Qatar played a crucial role in the pearl trade.

Sites of Human Settlement in Qatar Over the Ages

Archaeological remains indicate that the earliest human settlement in Qatar dates back to the 10th millennium BC. Notable sites of human settlement in Qatar include:

- **Neolithic Period:** Al-Khor, Bir Zekreet on the western coast, Al-Shagrah in southern Qatar, and Al-Zarqa.
- **Iron Age (from the end of the second millennium BC to the middle of the first century BC):** Al-Wusail, Umm Al-Ma', Ras Abrouq, and Abu Ghannam Island.
- **Hellenistic and Roman Periods (from 323 BC to 64 AD):** Umm Al-Ma', Al-Khor, and Abu Ghannam Island.
- **2nd to 7th Century AD:** Artifacts were found at the Al-Mazrouah site.

Examples of Artifacts Discovered in Qatar from Ancient Times

Many artifacts have been discovered in Qatar throughout ancient times, such as the fishermen's houses found at the site of Al-Shagrah, which date back to the Neolithic period and indicate a shift in human life from nomadism to settlement.

Additionally, in the Bir Zekreet site, burial mounds and large quantities of flint and stone tools were found, including arrowheads, scrapers with sharp edges for



scraping skins and tree bark, stone mills for grinding grains and spices, and hand axes used in agriculture. All these tools were made from hard flint and local limestone.

In conclusion, Qatar's geographical location played a prominent role in the emergence of ancient human settlements and in the connection and communication with neighbouring civilizations such as the Dilmun civilization and the Ubaid culture in Mesopotamia and Persia.



Qatar in the Islamic Era

Before the advent of Islam, Qatar was part of what is known in historical sources as the region of "Bilad Al-Bahrain," which extended from Basra to the coasts of Oman by sea, and to the borders of Al-Ahsa and Kuwait and the surrounding areas by land. This region was under the rule of the Arab Al-Mundhir. In the eighth year of Hijra, the Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him) sent his envoy Al-Ala Al-Hadrami to the ruler of Bahrain, Mundhir ibn Sawa Al-Tamimi, who governed the region on behalf of the Sassanid kings in Persia, inviting him to embrace Islam. Mundhir ibn Sawa responded to the Islamic call and began encouraging people to embrace Islam. This event marked a significant moment in the region's history, bringing Qatar into the fold of the Islamic state and civilization from that time onward. Qatar contributed during the Rashidun and Umayyad caliphates to spreading Islam in Persia and India and participated in preparing the first naval fleet to transport the Islamic army for jihad under the leadership of Al-Ala Al-Hadrami.

The Geographical Location of Qatar and Its Importance in the Islamic Era

Numerous references in the writings of Muslim geographers describe Qatar as a peninsula located within the borders of Oman and Al-Ahsa. Al-Bakri, who died in 1049, mentioned its location between Bahrain and Oman. Al-Firuzabadi, who died in 1127, referred to Qatar in his book "Al-Qamus Al-Muhit" as "a land between Al-Qatif and Oman." Yaqut Al-Hamawi, who died in 1228, described it in his book "Mu'jam Al-Buldan" as a village on the coast between Oman and Al-Uqayr, saying: "In the borders of Bahrain on the coast between Oman and Al-Uqayr, there is a village called Qatar, and the finest Qatari garments are attributed to it." Qatar includes several islands such as Hawar, Halul, and Shra'o. Al-Masudi (died 345/965)



also highlighted the importance of the islands surrounding Qatar. Al-Idrisi referred to the many islands scattered in the sea of Qatar, mentioning that some of them were uninhabited. Additionally, these islands played a significant economic and commercial role in the Middle Ages as they served as rest stops for traveling ships and sources of fresh water. Al-Hamdani (died 334/945) noted that they had "plenty of palm trees and water."

It is worth mentioning that the Arabian Gulf region, in general, has been distinguished since ancient times by its geographical location at the heart of the ancient world, which helped it control the main maritime and land trade routes that connected the East with the West. The people of the Arabian Gulf benefited from their location; after the advent of Islam, they established a network of trade relations with the countries of the eastern coast of Africa and Southeast Asia. These relations reached their peak during the third and fourth centuries AH (ninth and tenth centuries CE). Additionally, the people of the Gulf established trade relations with Europe and its peoples, such as the Slavs and the Rus, acting as commercial intermediaries in transporting goods from India and China to European markets through Gulf cities and ports, such as spices, wood, cotton, silk, paper, and musk. They also brought gold and slaves from the eastern coasts of Africa, and furs, white slaves, and swords from Europe. The coastal cities of the Gulf, such as Basra, Siraf, Hormuz, Al-Ahsa, and Sohar, flourished as a result of this commercial growth.

Qatar occupies a strategic central location on the western coast of the Arabian Gulf, making it a prominent trading hub on:

1. The maritime route connecting Iraq with the ports of the Indian Ocean and the eastern coast of Africa through Basra, Qatif, and Sohar. The numerous inlets and shallow waters in Qatar helped commercial ships and fishing vessels use them as harbours.



2. The land route connecting Iraq with Oman and the Arabian Peninsula (the Incense Route), where traders and pilgrims would take Qatar as a resting place to resupply with water and provisions.

This commercial prosperity continued during the Umayyad and Abbasid periods. The Umayyad caliphs (41-132 AH/661-750 CE) paid special attention to the Gulf coast, and Qatar was known for its prominent commercial status, pearl trade, and breeding of camels and horses. The trade routes during the Umayyad era played a pioneering role in continuing the Islamic conquests in the East and served as sources of military and food supplies for the conquerors. During the Abbasid period (132-656 AH/749-1258 CE), the Abbasid caliphs showed special interest in trade with the countries of the Far East and the eastern coast of Africa, flourishing their trade relations with India and China, then the Zanj coast (Mozambique) and Madagascar, leading to general prosperity and economic revival in the Gulf region.

It is important to note the decline of this commercial role after the spread of the Qarmatians' movement in the late third century AH in eastern Arabia, Bahrain, and Al-Ahsa. This movement opposed the Abbasid rule, and the Qarmatians' rule continued for two centuries until Abdullah ibn Ali Al-Ayyuni, with the help of the Abbasid caliphate in Baghdad, managed to eliminate them and establish his state, which his sons and grandsons inherited, ruling Bahrain, Al-Ahsa, and Qatar. This state was known as the Al-Ayuni or Al-Ayuniya state.



Economic Life in Qatar During the Islamic Era:

Qatar was famous during the early Islamic centuries for various economic activities, including:

Textiles:

The people of the Qatar Peninsula were renowned for their expertise in textile and garment-making. The Qatari textiles, known as "Al-Qitriya," gained wide fame and were highly sought after throughout the Arabian Peninsula due to their high quality, distinctive colors, and soft texture. It is reported that the Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him) wore a Qatari garment, and the Mother of the Believers, Aisha (May Allah be pleased with her), wore a dress made from Qatari fabric. Umar ibn Al-Khattab (may Allah be pleased with him) also owned a patched Qatari loincloth made of leather.

Perhaps the most famous of these textiles were the "Burdah Qatariyah" (plural of Burdah), which was a cloak for protection from the cold, the Qatari "Izaar," a garment that covered the lower body, and the "Hullah" (plural of Hullah), which was men's attire consisting of a robe and a shirt completed with a turban, or a shirt, loincloth, and robe. The people of Qatar also excelled in making "Al-Asab," a type of striped textile, competing with the people of Yemen in its production. Additionally, the people of Qatar were famous for making turbans, which were head coverings wound into a circular shape and worn on formal occasions.

Qatar was thus known for its diverse range of woolen garments and textiles, and exported significant quantities of raw textiles and clothing.



Pearl Diving:

Qatar was renowned for its numerous pearl diving sites, and its people were highly skilled in the craft of pearl diving and the pearl trade, a tradition passed down through generations. Qatari pearls, especially the large, round ones, were considered some of the finest, fetching high prices in markets in India and East Africa. The pearl trade was a major source of income for Qataris, who continued this practice until the early 20th century, when the introduction of cultured pearls in Japan diminished its significance.

Camel Herding and Breeding:

During the Islamic era, Qatar was known as a center for camel herding and breeding. Camels were not only used for transportation, but they also provided meat, milk, and its derivatives, while their hides, wool, and hair were used for clothing and shelter. Islamic sources highlight the reputation of Qatari camels, which were known for their strength, agility, and speed, and were referred to as "Qatari camels" in reference to their origin.

In conclusion, Qatar's geographical location played a crucial role in its economic prosperity and in establishing connections between its people and the civilizations of the ancient world.



International Rivalry in the Arabian Gulf during the 16th and 17th Centuries

From the early years of the modern era, the Arabian Gulf region witnessed competition among European colonial powers and the Ottoman Empire, all vying for control and influence due to the region's strategic location and its potential for enhancing trade exchanges. What were the nature of these competing powers and the manifestations of this rivalry?

First: The Portuguese: The Portuguese played a significant role in the modern history of the Arabian Gulf. Realizing that their maritime state, located along the Atlantic Ocean, could not expand within the Iberian Peninsula, the Portuguese began seeking other areas for expansion following the maritime renaissance that occurred in their country from the late 14th century. They succeeded in extending their naval activities along the western coast of Africa. In 1498, Vasco da Gama utilized geographical information found in the writings of the Arab navigator Ahmad ibn Majid to reach the Cape of Good Hope, which paved the way to India. This voyage laid the foundation for European colonization in those regions and opened the door for the Portuguese to establish an empire in the East. To achieve this, they sought to control Indian waters, pushing the Arabs into their internal seas and closing them off by seizing key entrances.

The factors driving the Portuguese towards the Arabian seas and the coasts of the Arabian Peninsula included:

1. The fragmentation of the Arab Islamic state due to the weakening of ruling political powers and their preoccupation with sectarian and political conflicts.



2. The Portuguese desire to monopolize Eastern trade, particularly in spices and silk.

3. The crusading spirit that dominated the Portuguese and their leaders, especially Afonso de Albuquerque.

The Portuguese interest in the Arabian Gulf began after they reached the Indian coasts in 1505 and succeeded in establishing a government in Goa.

Portuguese Expansion into the Gulf:

In 1506, the Portuguese king sent a fleet to the East under the command of Afonso de Albuquerque to reinforce Portuguese presence along the coasts. Their goal was to close off trade routes used by Arabs and Muslims, including seizing the island of Socotra at the southern entrance of the Red Sea in 1507, where they established a military garrison. They attempted to seize Bab al-Mandeb and Aden but failed due to significant Arab resistance. The Red Sea was particularly appealing to the Portuguese because of its proximity to the holy sites.

Later that same year, Albuquerque moved to control the Arabian Gulf by seizing Hormuz. The Portuguese also captured Ras al-Hadd, Qalhat, Muscat, and Sohar, eventually reaching Hormuz, whose ruler submitted to the Portuguese. In 1521, the Portuguese occupied Bahrain, which was rich in pearl diving sites, despite the resistance from its ruler Muqrin ibn Zamil Al Jabri, and they built a strong fort there.

Second: The Islamic Political Powers and Their Stance on the Portuguese:

This refers to the Mamluk Sultanate in Egypt and the Levant, the Safavid Empire in Persia, and the Ottoman Empire in Asia and Eastern Europe.

The Mamluks: The Mamluk Sultanate was the most affected by the arrival of the Portuguese in the Indian Ocean, as the spice trade passed through Arab lands under their control. As a result, the Mamluks were the first to respond to the Portuguese threat. Sultan Qansuh al-Ghuri of Egypt dispatched a large naval expedition



against the Portuguese, led by his deputy in Jeddah, Hussein al-Kurdi, in 1505. The Mamluk fleet reached the island of Diu and engaged the Portuguese fleet, commanded by Lorenzo de Almeida, in 1509. The battle resulted in a Portuguese victory over the Mamluk fleet.

Therefore, it became the responsibility of the Ottoman Empire, as the successor to the Mamluk Sultanate following the conquest of Egypt in 1517, to confront the Portuguese threat in the Arabian Gulf, which endangered the holy sites. **The Safavids:** Albuquerque recognized the conflict between the Persians and the Ottomans, which prompted him to swiftly form an alliance with Shah Ismail I of Persia in 1515. The Hormuz Agreement between the Persians and the Portuguese was established following the Persian defeat at the Battle of Chaldiran in 1514 against the Ottomans. This agreement highlighted the mutual desire of both parties to cooperate against the Ottomans. The key points of the agreement between the Portuguese commander, Albuquerque, and Shah Ismail I included:

1. The Portuguese would provide some ships to the Shah to enable him to conquer Bahrain and Al-Qatif.
2. The Portuguese would assist the Shah in suppressing the Mokrani revolt in exchange for the Shah's approval of Portuguese control over the port of Gwadar on the Balochistan coast.
3. Portugal and Persia would form an alliance against the Ottoman Empire.
4. The Shah would cede Hormuz to the Portuguese and acknowledge Portuguese protection over it.

This agreement provided the Portuguese with a significant opportunity to establish a stable presence in the Arabian Gulf waters, reinforcing their position in Hormuz, which they transformed into their most powerful stronghold in the region.



The Ottomans: The Ottoman Empire was founded in 1299 in Asia Minor (modern-day Turkey) and reached its zenith in the 16th century, expanding across three continents: Asia, Africa, and Europe. Initially, the Ottoman Sultans focused on their conquests in Europe, but by the early 16th century, they turned their attention towards the Arabian Gulf and the Arabian Peninsula for several reasons:

1. **Perceived Threat:** The Ottomans felt threatened by the expansion of their rival, the Safavid Empire, into the Arab region, particularly after the Safavids reached the eastern coast of the Arabian Gulf and occupied Baghdad and Mosul in 1508. Safavid ruler Shah Ismail I also formed alliances with local rulers and chiefs, making the Safavid presence a direct challenge to the southern borders of the Ottoman Empire.
2. **Protection of Holy Sites:** The Ottomans were motivated to protect the holy sites from Portuguese incursions and to gain the support of Muslims.
3. **Control of Trade Routes:** The Ottomans aimed to dominate the strategic trade routes in the region.

This rivalry led to one of the most significant battles in the region's history: the Battle of Chaldiran in 1514, where Ottoman Sultan Selim I defeated the Safavids. Following this victory, Sultan Suleiman the Magnificent successfully established the Ottoman province of Basra, extending Ottoman influence to the islands of Qeshm, Hormuz, and Al-Qatif.

The Ottoman Empire attempted to counter the Portuguese efforts to enter the Red Sea after replacing the Mamluk Sultanate in Egypt in 1517. To do this, the Ottomans launched a significant military campaign from Egypt (Suez Port) under the command of the Governor of Egypt, Suleiman Pasha Al-Khadim, targeting the Portuguese in the Indian Ocean. Although the campaign succeeded in capturing



Yemen, the Ottomans were ultimately defeated by the Portuguese at the naval Battle of Diu in 1538.

However, the Ottomans were unable to expel the Portuguese from the Arabian Gulf due to several reasons, including the relatively small and weak Ottoman fleet in the southern Arabian seas (both the Red Sea and the Arabian Gulf) and the distance of their primary naval bases in the Mediterranean from the theater of operations in the Indian Ocean. Additionally, the ongoing Ottoman-Persian conflict, which led the Persians to ally with the Portuguese, along with the multiple battlefronts, overextended the Ottomans' military resources. Consequently, the Ottomans were only able to maintain a small garrison in Al-Ahsa, which was eventually defeated by the Banu Khalid in 1670. The Ottomans did not reappear militarily in the region until the late 19th century during their campaign in Al-Ahsa.

The Yarubids

The Yarubid dynasty, which emerged in Oman, successfully unified the country internally and sought to eliminate Portuguese strongholds along the Omani coast. In 1650, Imam Sultan bin Saif managed to recapture Muscat from the Portuguese. This marked the end of Portuguese control in Muscat, which was the last of their strongholds in the Arabian Gulf. The Portuguese withdrawal from the region created an opportunity for the Dutch, French, and British to establish a presence, leading to a series of rivalries and conflicts among these European powers during the 17th and 18th centuries.

The Decline of Portuguese Presence in the Arabian Gulf:

Despite Portugal's success in establishing a vast empire in the 16th century, their military power began to decline by the end of that century. The Portuguese Empire in the East did not last long, as it started to collapse in the early 17th century.

The Dutch and English arrived in the Arabian Gulf at the beginning of the 17th century, at a time when the Portuguese had already established strong bases and



outposts in the region. The Dutch and English quickly realized that their success depended on eliminating Portuguese influence. Unlike the Portuguese, the Dutch and English were driven by commercial and political ambitions rather than the crusading zeal that had initially motivated the Portuguese.

The English successfully defeated the Portuguese near the port of Jask and the island of Qeshm in 1600. Following this victory, the English sought to establish an alliance with Shah Abbas the Great of Persia. This alliance aimed to eliminate Portuguese influence on the Persian coasts in exchange for granting the English significant trade privileges. As a result, Shah Abbas allied with the English to drive the Portuguese out of Bahrain and Hormuz permanently. The Shah, with the assistance of the English and the people of Bahrain, succeeded in expelling the Portuguese. They besieged the Portuguese military base in Hormuz and successfully captured it in 1622. One of the significant advantages that the British East India Company gained from this alliance was the establishment of a trading post at the port of Bandar Abbas.

Several factors contributed to the weakening and eventual collapse of Portuguese power in the Arabian Gulf:

1. Spain's successful occupation of Portugal from 1580 to 1640.
2. The Portuguese policies of intolerance, greed, and cruelty which led to frequent uprisings against them.
3. The limited Portuguese population in the colonized regions.
4. The government's monopolization of profitable goods and the failure to allow open trade, leading to corruption in the Portuguese administration, along with disorder in the Portuguese navy due to mutinies and conflicts among senior officers.



5. The emergence of rival naval powers, particularly the Dutch and the English, who successfully displaced the Portuguese from their positions in the Arabian Gulf.

6. The resistance displayed by the Ya'rubis in Oman.

Third: The British Presence in the Gulf

The British colonial presence in Asia began with the establishment of the English East India Company (later renamed the British East India Company) in 1600. This was a colonial enterprise disguised as a trading company, which allowed its members to extend their country's influence across Asia and the Indian Ocean, reaching the Arabian Gulf, not through direct conflict with the local populations but via trade.

A. The Anglo-Persian-Dutch Alliance Against the Portuguese

This alliance was formed after the relationship between the Persians and the Portuguese shifted from friendship to tension and hostility, coinciding with Shah Abbas's desire to weaken Arab powers in the Gulf and the emergence of the Dutch as a competing force in the region. The result was a tripartite alliance between the English, Dutch, and Persians against the Portuguese. Their combined efforts led to naval battles in the Gulf against the Portuguese fleet, with the English securing their first agency in the Gulf at the Omani city of Jask. However, the English had greater ambitions, leading them to negotiate a treaty with the Persian ruler, granting them control over Hormuz and exempting English goods from taxes in Persia. The joint English-Persian-Dutch fleet fought a significant battle at Hormuz in 1622, which destroyed the last Portuguese stronghold in the southern Gulf. The English emerged as a real power in the region, expanding their influence through treaties and agreements with Arab powers. The following year, the English established a trading post in Bandar Abbas.



B. Anglo-Dutch Rivalry

Although the Anglo-Dutch naval alliance successfully ended Portuguese influence in the Gulf, this partnership did not last long. As soon as the English established themselves in Hormuz and the Gulf, a new rival force emerged in the form of the Dutch, who succeeded in establishing themselves at Bandar Abbas and made it their trading center. This raised English concerns, coinciding with political tensions between the two nations in Europe. In response, the English moved their trading center from Bandar Abbas to Basra, seeking to distance themselves from Dutch competition and strengthen ties with the Ottoman authorities.

The Dutch began to feel the pressure of their position after facing local revolts and continued attacks from Mir Mahna, which ultimately culminated in the end of Dutch influence in the Gulf in 1765. Consequently, Britain was left as the dominant power in the Arabian Gulf but soon found itself facing increasing French presence, prompting Britain to prepare strategies to counter it.



Political Conditions in Qatar and Local Powers in the Gulf Until the 19th Century

Qatar has historically been an integral part of the Al-Ahsa region, which witnessed numerous historical events and developments. This region was under the control of the Islamic Caliphate, whether in Hijaz, the Levant, or Baghdad, until the Qarmatians sacked its capital, Hajr, and built Al-Ahsa as the new capital. Over time, the region came under the rule of several local powers, the most prominent being Bani Khalid (1670-1793). Although the Ottoman Empire began expanding into the Arab world in the early 16th century, it struggled to establish a strong naval base to exert control over the Gulf. This was due to tribal conflicts and the empire's preoccupation with wars against the Safavid Empire. After the Ottomans took control of the Al-Ahsa region in the 16th century and brought the Ajwad bin Zamil Al-Jabri clan under their influence, they appointed Fatih Pasha as the first Ottoman governor. However, due to weak Ottoman control, the Al-Humaid branch of Bani Khalid seized the opportunity to assert control over Al-Ahsa, wresting it from the Ottomans in 1670. Bani Khalid granted local sheikhs a degree of autonomy in the areas under their control. The Qatar Peninsula, like much of the western Gulf coast, came under Bani Khalid's influence until the late 18th century. The Al Muslim family, based in Al-Huwailah, was tasked by the Emir of Al-Ahsa with collecting annual taxes from the people of Qatar and sending them to Al-Ahsa. As the Al Muslim family managed Qatari affairs during Bani Khalid's dominance, they gained significant influence over Qatar's inhabitants, a period that ended in 1793 with the rise of the First Saudi State founded by Muhammad bin Saud.



The Ottoman Empire did not attempt to reassert its influence in Al-Ahsa due to its preoccupation with problems in Europe and the Balkans. This weakening of Ottoman power in the Gulf allowed British India to expand its control over the region. The British used military force and treaties, such as the General Maritime Treaty and agreements to combat piracy, the slave trade, and the arms trade, to establish their dominance. These pretexts allowed the British to impose their influence and control over the Arabian Gulf.

While the southern coast of the Arabian Gulf became a British sphere of influence, Ottoman authority in the region was nominal. Ottoman sovereignty over Kuwait was limited, with no real power, symbolized merely by raising the Ottoman flag over the Sheikh's palace. In Bahrain, the sheikhs accepted ties with the Ottoman Empire as a counterbalance to British and Persian ambitions. However, Britain opposed this and removed the Ottoman flag when the Bahraini sheikhs raised it.

The Migration of the Utub

At the end of the 17th century, the Arabian Gulf region witnessed the migration of several tribal groups from the central Arabian Peninsula. Among these groups, the Utub alliance, which included the Al Sabah, Al Khalifa, and Al Jalahma families, became prominent. Many studies suggest that the Utub trace their lineage back to the Anza tribe. The name "Utub" is believed to be derived from the Arabic verb "ataaba," meaning "to move frequently," which reflects their history of frequent migrations. The Utub migrated from their original homeland in the Al-Haddar region of Al-Aflaj, located in the southeast of Najd, during the late 17th and early 18th centuries. Several factors motivated this migration, including severe drought, the search for new sources of livelihood, and tribal conflicts. The Utub, along with the Al Maadeed and other tribes, eventually settled on the western coast of the Arabian Gulf. The three branches of the Utub—Al Khalifa, Al Sabah, and Al Jalahma—established themselves in the strategically located Qatar Peninsula, specifically in the town of Al Zubarah in the northwest.

Several factors made Al Zubarah an ideal location for the Utub:

1. **Access to the Arabian Gulf:** Al Zubarah was located on the coast, providing access to the sea.
2. **Availability of Fresh Water:** The area had a reliable supply of fresh water.
3. **Proximity to Pearl Diving Sites:** The region was close to rich pearl diving grounds.
4. **Abundant Grazing Land and Firewood:** The area provided ample resources for sustenance.

There is some disagreement among sources regarding the exact date of the Utub's arrival in Qatar, with estimates ranging from 1670 onward. Similarly, the



duration of their stay in Qatar before moving to Kuwait varies, with estimates ranging from 20 to 50 years.

During their time in Qatar, the Utub were welcomed by the Al Muslim family, a branch of the Bani Khalid tribe, which goes back to al-Jaboor family, who managed local affairs from their base in Al-Huwailah.

The Utub engaged in various economic activities, including pearl diving, fishing, trade, and agriculture, amassing considerable wealth. However, tensions eventually arose between the Utub and the Al Muslim family when the Utub began to withhold the taxes and dues owed to the Al Muslim family, leading to a conflict that culminated in the Utub's departure for Kuwait after a battle at Ras Tanura. The Utub settled in Kuwait between 1716 and 1766, establishing their first emirate there in 1752. Leadership roles were divided among the Utub tribes, with Sheikh Sabah bin Jaber Al-Utbi handling governance and Sheikh Khalifa bin Mohammed Al-Utbi managing finances from pearl sales, trade, and taxes.

Kuwait prospered under the Utub's commercial activities, but internal disputes eventually led the Al Khalifa family to leave Kuwait and head towards Bahrain. When Bahrain's ruler, Nasr Al-Madhkur, denied them entry, they returned to Qatar and resettled in Al Zubarah in 1766 under the leadership of Mohammed bin Khalifa. The Al Khalifa family's return to Al Zubarah was motivated by

1. Their extensive knowledge of the region.
2. The area's strategic and commercial importance.
3. The lack of opposition from Qatari tribes due to their frequent visits to the region.
4. Their successful establishment of strong relations with the local Qatari tribes, lending them money and revitalizing the pearl trade.

Al Zubarah flourished as a trade center, especially following the migration of wealthy Basra merchants fleeing Persian occupation (1775-1779). When the Al



Khalifa family felt strong enough, they built the Al Murair Fort and fortified themselves there. However, their refusal to continue paying dues to the Al Muslim family eventually led to a breakdown in relations.

While the Al Khalifa family primarily occupied Al Zubarah, the rest of the Qatar Peninsula was inhabited by various tribes, including the Al Maadeed (the Al Thani family hails from this tribe), the Al Buainain, Sudan, Al Bin Ali, Al Kubaisi, Al Khulaifat, Al Bu Kuwara, Al Sulaiti, Al Manasir, Al Mohannadi, as well as the Hawala, Manasir, Bani Murrah, Al Hajri, Al Kaabi, and some members of the Al Nuaimi tribe. These tribes largely managed their own affairs, with most of them concentrated in Al Bidda, Al Wakrah, Al Huwailah, Al Fuwairit, and Khawr Hassan. When Al Zubarah could no longer satisfy the ambitions of the Al Khalifa family, and realizing that further expansion in the Qatar Peninsula would lead to conflict with Qatari tribes and Bani Khalid, they turned their attention to Bahrain, which was under the rule of the Al Madhkur family.

After a successful campaign in 1783, supported by their allies from the Al Sabah, Al Jalahma, and Qatari tribes, the Al Khalifa family overthrew the Persian garrison in Manama and took control of the Bahrain Islands, establishing an Arab emirate under Sheikh Ahmed Al Khalifa. Sheikh Ahmed continued to move between Bahrain and Al Zubarah until he died in 1794, after which the ruling family relocated to Bahrain. When the Al Jalahma family felt mistreated by the Al Khalifa family, they moved to Khawr Hassan on the Qatari coast under their leader, Rahmah bin Jaber, and began retaliating against their former allies by attacking ships in the region. This continued until Rahmah bin Jaber's death in a naval battle around 1828.



Qatar and the First Saudi State

After the agreement between Sheikh Muhammad bin Abdul Wahhab and the Emir of Diriyah, Muhammad bin Saud, in 1744, which marked the beginning of the Saudi state with its center in Diriyah, the Emirate of Diriyah began expanding within Najd and solidified its power there. It then moved to challenge the influence of the Bani Khalid in Al-Ahsa, eventually conquering Al-Ahsa and ending Bani Khalid's rule in 1793. Al-Ahsa was then used as a base for launching attacks on Oman, Al-Buraimi, Qatar, Bahrain, and the rest of the Arabian Gulf. A province comprising Al-Qatif, Qatar, and Bahrain was established under Saudi control, with Abdullah bin Aufaisan appointed as its governor, headquartered in Bahrain. Zakat funds collected from the region were sent to the provincial capital in Bahrain and then to Diriyah, the capital of the Saudi state. However, this situation did not last long, as the Saudi state became a significant threat to Ottoman political and religious influence in the Arabian Peninsula, especially after the Saudis took control of the Hejaz. This prompted the Ottoman Sultan to instruct the Ottoman governor of Egypt, Muhammad Ali Pasha, to act. His forces succeeded in entering Diriyah, destroying it, and ending Saudi rule there in 1818, effectively ending Saudi influence in Al-Ahsa and the Gulf coasts, especially after the Sultan of Muscat attacked Al-Zubarah, Khawr Hassan, and the Bahrain Islands, expelling the Saudi garrisons from these areas.



Britain and Qatar

Britain's direct contact with Qatar was primarily focused on monitoring the activities of Rahmah bin Jaber. Their encounter with Qatari tribes and sheikhs occurred later than other political and tribal entities in the Gulf after Britain established the General Maritime Peace Treaties in 1820. During his stay in Khawr Hassan that year, Rahmah bin Jaber attacked passing ships, and refused to join the General Maritime Peace. In response, the British East India Company sent the warship "Vestal" in 1821 and bombarded the town of Al-Bidaa, leading to its destruction and the migration of hundreds of its inhabitants to the islands between Qatar and the Omani coast. This British bombardment of Qatar's coast marked the first direct contact between Britain and the Qatar Peninsula.

The second British contact with Qatar's coast occurred when the British political resident in the Gulf, McLeod, visited Doha in January 1823 during a tour of the Gulf's coasts. He found that prominent members of the Al Buainain tribe wielded significant influence in Doha and believed the area was under Bahrain's jurisdiction and thus subject to the General Maritime Peace treaty signed by Bahrain's sheikhs with Britain in February 1820. However, he discovered that this was not the case, as the local commercial ships in Doha's port did not display the flags stipulated by the treaty or carry the necessary licenses. This indicated that the Qatari tribes were unaware of the treaty and were not under the authority of the Al Khalifa family in Bahrain, who had signed the treaty. As a result, the British resident ordered a survey of ships, the issuance of necessary licenses, and the raising of treaty flags, along with a comprehensive survey of Qatar's coasts and eastern waters.

Between 1835 and 1836, there was an increase in attacks on British ships in the Gulf. British authorities blamed refugees from the Omani coast who had settled in



Khawr Al-Udayd. They accused Qataris of sympathizing with them and sent a naval force to Qatar's coast, imposing obligations on the sheikhs of Doha, Al-Wakrah, and Al-Udayd to either seize the "pirates" boats or pay fines. Britain then decided to include Qatar in the maritime truce agreements made with Gulf sheikhs in 1835. However, the attacks on ships continued, leading to another British naval bombardment of Doha in 1841, with demands for compensation from the Sheikh of Doha.

The Al Khalifa's Attempts to Establish Control Over Qatari Tribes After the Fall of the First Saudi State

After the forces of Muhammad Ali Pasha withdrew from Najd, the Saudis sought to re-establish their rule, making Riyadh their capital. As they expanded eastward to reach Al-Ahsa, the Sheikh of Bahrain, Abdullah bin Ahmad Al Khalifa, became concerned about the Saudi expansion. To secure his rule, he, along with his sons Mubarak and Nasser Al Khalifa, moved to the coasts of Qatar to monitor the movements of the emerging Second Saudi State under Turki bin Abdullah Al Saud. The Al Khalifa rulers soon faced resistance from the inhabitants of Al-Huwaylah, who rebelled and refused to submit to their authority. Additionally, disputes between the Al Khalifa and the tribes of Al Buainain and Al Bin Ali, who withdrew significant portions of their tribes to Abu Dhabi, reflected the broader resistance among Qatari tribes against Al Khalifa's control. By 1831, Emir Faisal bin Turki Al Saud managed to consolidate his power in Al-Ahsa and the Arabian Gulf, starting to collect zakat from the Al Khalifa and bringing several tribes, including the Manasir, Al Murrah, and Ajman, under his rule.

During this period, significant changes occurred in the Qatar Peninsula that shaped its future political landscape:

1. Attempts by the Bahrain Utub (Al Khalifa, Al Jalahma) to fill the political vacuum left by the fall of the First Saudi State.



2. Ongoing conflicts between the Al Jalahma, led by Rahmah bin Jaber, and the Al Khalifa, which caused concern among the British in the region.
3. Rejection by Qatari tribes of the Al Khalifa's attempts to impose their control over Qatar.
4. British claims of increased attacks on ships from the Qatari coast, allegedly carried out by refugees from the Omani coast.
5. Intensification of internal conflicts over rule in Bahrain, with the Qatar Peninsula becoming a battleground for this struggle.
6. The return of the Second Saudi State's efforts to assert influence over Qatar and Bahrain.
7. The growing strength of Qatari tribes and the emergence of the Al Thani family, which played a crucial role in providing the local leadership needed to free Qatar from any external power or influence.

Internal Conflict Over Rule in Bahrain (1840-1843)

Between 1840 and 1843, Bahrain experienced an internal struggle for power among the members of the Al Khalifa family, which had significant repercussions in Qatar. Sheikh Mohammed bin Khalifa challenged the authority of his grandfather (or great-uncle), Sheikh Abdullah bin Ahmad, after the withdrawal of Egyptian forces from Al-Ahsa in 1840. Mohammed bin Khalifa relocated to Qatar and sought to form alliances with its inhabitants to support his bid for power in Bahrain. Meanwhile, Sheikh Abdullah faced opposition from his sons, leading to instability in Bahrain.

Despite a brief reconciliation between the two rival sheikhs, the conflict resurfaced in 1842 and spilled over into the Qatar Peninsula. The civil war in Bahrain gave local Qatari powers an opportunity to assert themselves when Sheikh Mohammed bin Khalifa sought their assistance. Initially, Sheikh Mohammed bin Thani, residing in Al Fuwayrit, did not respond to Mohammed bin Khalifa's request for help. However, after seeking support from Qataris in Doha and Al Khor, Mohammed bin Thani and the Al Maadeed tribe agreed to assist him, along with support from Isa bin Tarif and the Al Bin Ali tribe, who had returned to Doha, and the Al Jalahma tribe.

Mohammed bin Khalifa assembled a significant force from Qatari tribes, using Al Fuwayrit as a base, and by April 1843, he successfully captured Bahrain. Sheikh Abdullah bin Ahmad fled to Al Dammam with his family. The involvement of Qatari forces in placing Mohammed bin Khalifa in power in Bahrain marked a newfound strength among the Qatari tribes, which played a crucial role in the region's dynamics.



However, tensions soon arose between Isa bin Tarif, the leader of the Al Bin Ali, and Sheikh Mohammed bin Khalifa, leading to a battle near Al Fuwayrit at a site called "Umm Suwayyah" in 1847. Although Isa initially won the battle, he was eventually killed, leading to a severe defeat for his forces, which forced the Al Bin Ali tribe to leave Qatar. Former hopes of restoring Sheikh Abdullah to power in Bahrain were dashed.

In 1850, Emir Faisal bin Turki Al Saud advanced with his forces towards Qatar as part of a tour to inspect the regions under his control. When he approached near Doha, the local inhabitants, along with those from Al Wakrah and Al Fuwayrit, rushed to him, declaring their rejection of allegiance to the Sheikh of Bahrain and expressing their willingness to align with the Saudi state. Faisal decided to discipline the Al Khalifa family, so he instructed Sheikh Mohammed bin Thani, who had become the leader of the Qatari tribes and was residing in Doha along with most of the Al Maadeed tribe, to prepare ships with provisions and water. He also wrote to Bishr bin Rahmah, the leader of the Al Jalahma tribe, to move his group to Al Bidda (Doha). The people of Bahrain became aware of these preparations and prepared to confront their allied adversaries who were heading towards Bahrain. In a battle known as the "Battle of Al Maseemeer," the Al Khalifa emerged victorious.

As the Al Khalifa family realized that the Qatari forces led by Mohammed bin Thani and his son Jassim were resisting their attempts to extend influence over the Qatari tribes, they assembled an army to subdue these tribes. They sought assistance from Sheikh Saeed bin Tahnun, the ruler of Abu Dhabi, who responded by leading his forces alongside the Bahraini army to besiege Doha from the sea. Consequently, the Qataris had to rely on supplies from Al-Ahsa. The skirmishes dragged on, but the besiegers did not dare to storm Doha due to the presence of a Saudi force there. The situation was eventually resolved through a settlement in which the Saudis



accepted an annual tribute from the ruler of Bahrain in exchange for recognizing his authority over Qatar.

Nevertheless, the tension persisted. In 1859, the Saudi governor of Al-Ahsa, with the support of Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdullah, the son of the former ruler of Bahrain, began preparing for a new attempt to invade Bahrain and install Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdullah as its ruler. The ostensible reason for this was the claim that the Sheikh of Bahrain had incited some Qatari tribes to attack the Saudi ruler's subjects. However, the intervention of the British navy completely thwarted the attempt. Subsequently, in May 1861, British authorities signed an agreement with Sheikh Mohammed bin Khalifa, in which he acknowledged the validity and applicability of the agreements and treaties his predecessors had made with the British government. In return, he pledged to abstain from warfare, piracy, and the slave trade, in exchange for British protection of Bahrain against any attacks.



The Impact of Bahrain's Internal Conflict on Qatar

The internal conflict over power in Bahrain, which spread to Qatari territory and involved its tribes, had significant effects on Qatar's political situation. These effects include:

1. **Involvement in Bahraini Conflict:** Qatar and its tribes became key players in the struggle for power in Bahrain during the civil war (1834–1840). Sheikh Mohammed bin Khalifa, one of the disputants, sought to form an alliance with Qatari tribes to invade Bahrain and seize power, successfully achieving this with the support of Qatari tribes.
2. **Strained Relations and Alliances:** The strained relations between the Al Khalifa family and the Second Saudi State coincided with understandings between Sheikh Mohammed bin Thani and Faisal bin Turki, which helped avoid a confrontation between Qatari tribes and the Saudi state. This also strengthened Sheikh Mohammed bin Thani's position among the Qatari tribes. However, this reconciliation was viewed as a threat by Mohammed bin Khalifa, leading him to seek assistance from the ruler of Abu Dhabi, Sheikh Saeed bin Tahnoun, to invade Qatar and impose a naval blockade on Doha.
3. **Resistance to Al Khalifa's Control:** Efforts by Bahrain's rulers to impose their authority on Qatari tribes before the emergence of the Emirate faced resistance. This resistance grew as Sheikh Mohammed bin Thani gained prominence, gradually steering Qatar towards independence from external powers.
4. **Ongoing Tension:** Tensions persisted between Qatari tribes, led by Sheikh Mohammed Al Thani, and the Al Khalifa family. The Al Khalifa family believed their authority over Qatar was linked to the tribute paid to Faisal Al



Saud, while the Qatari tribes, led by Mohammed bin Thani, angered the Al Khalifa family by reaching an understanding with the Saudi state. Tensions between the Al

5. Khalifa family and the Qatari tribes were further exacerbated by the dislike of the Al Khalifa representative in Al Wakrah, Ahmed bin Mohammed Al Khalifa. His harshness and poor management, particularly after his men attacked and seized a caravan belonging to the Al Naim tribe in the Al Wakrah market in 1866, contributed significantly to the strained relations just before the emergence of the Qatar Emirate.
6. **Increasing Independence:** The independence movement led by Sheikh Jassim Al Thani, opposing Al Khalifa's attempts to control Qatar, became evident in 1867 when he demanded the removal of all signs of Al Khalifa's influence in Qatar. In response, the Al Khalifa family plotted to eliminate Sheikh Jassim, particularly as he began to demonstrate his ability to lead the Qatari tribes and confront the dangers surrounding Qatar. The Al Khalifa family deceitfully lured Sheikh Jassim out of Qatar and imprisoned him in Bahrain in 1867. During his absence, the Al Khalifa, along with the Sheikh of Abu Dhabi, launched an attack on Doha and Al Wakrah, causing significant destruction and displacing many of the inhabitants.
7. **British Intervention:** The escalation of tribal conflicts between Qatar and Bahrain following the attack by the Al Khalifa family and the ruler of Abu Dhabi on Doha and Al Wakrah in 1867 prompted British authorities to take action to maintain maritime peace in the region and prevent any threat to navigation in the Gulf. In response, the Qatari tribes organized and launched a significant naval assault on Bahrain in the Battle of Damassa in June 1868. This battle led to the release of Sheikh Jassim Al Thani. The British intervention, led by the Gulf Resident, Lewis Pelly, aimed to uphold the



maritime peace that Britain had long sought to enforce in the region to protect its interests. Pelly took a firm stance against Bahrain and Abu Dhabi for violating the maritime peace agreements between Britain and the regional sheikhs, which included commitments not to engage in any hostile actions at sea. As part of the punitive measures, Pelly imposed financial fines on Bahrain and Abu Dhabi, removed Mohammed bin Khalifa from power in Bahrain, appointed Ali Al Khalifa as the new ruler, and required him to commit to maintaining peace at sea and refraining from any aggressive actions.

8. **Rising Qatari Unity:** The involvement of Qatari tribes in the internal struggle for power in Bahrain had a significant impact on these tribes. They began to realize their own strength when they united and started to consider the possibility of establishing an independent entity, similar to other neighboring sheikhdoms in the region. This growing sense of self-reliance led them to believe that they could prevent any external influence from controlling them.
9. **Emergence of Leadership:** The emergence of Sheikh Mohammed bin Thani, followed by his son Sheikh Jassim, provided the necessary leadership that motivated the tribes to pursue independence and self-governance in the Qatar Peninsula. For example, Sheikh Mohammed bin Thani signed a treaty on September 12, 1868, which was an extension of the maritime peace treaties previously signed between Britain and the Gulf Emirates. Historians have marked this treaty as the beginning of modern Qatar's history, signifying the emergence of Qatar as an independent emirate.



The Emergence of the Al Thani Family

The Al Thani family belongs to the Al Maadeed, a branch of the Al-Wahbah tribe, which traces its lineage back to Tamim. The family migrated from the Arabian Peninsula in the late 17th century, with some accounts suggesting they arrived in the Qatar Peninsula in the early 18th century. The Al Thani family originally migrated from the town of "Ushaiger," eventually settling in the "Jabrin" oasis in the southeast of the Qatar Peninsula. From there, they moved to "Iskaak," then "Al-Ruwais," "Zubarah," and "Fuwayrit," before finally settling in Doha in 1848.

Historians agree that the Al Thani family rose to leadership among the Qatari tribes due to their social and economic status, despite not being the largest tribe by numbers. Their great grandfather, "Thani," who was born in Zubarah and became a prominent pearl trader, successfully accumulated significant wealth and social standing, allowing him to unify the Qatari tribes. The Al Thani family was known for its sophistication and progressiveness, traits associated with the Al Maadeed. Thani secured a level of authority in the area surrounding Al-Bida, which helped elevate his son, "Mohammed bin Thani," born in Fuwayrit, to leadership of the Al Thani family and the Al Maadeed tribe. Mohammed bin Thani gained prominence by leading some Qatari tribes in supporting Mohammed bin Khalifa in seizing power in Bahrain (1842-1843) and further cemented his influence following the death of Isa bin Tarif.

When the traveler "Palgrave" visited Qatar in January 1863, he met Mohammed bin Thani, whom he described as "the ruler of Al-Bida, recognized by everyone as the leader of the entire region." Palgrave characterized him as shrewd, wise, simple in demeanor, yet cheerful, tough in negotiations, practical, literate in poetry, and knowledgeable in medicine. Palgrave also met Sheikh Jassim bin



Mohammed bin Thani, describing him as more impulsive than his father. He noted that Sheikh Jassim's residence resembled a fortress and mentioned that Doha, a village north of Al-Bida, was half its size, with its leader acknowledging Mohammed bin Thani's authority.

Amid the developments of the internal struggle for power in Bahrain and its spillover into Qatar, with various parties involved in the conflict, the maritime peace in the region was threatened, especially after the attack by the ruler of Bahrain, Mohammed bin Khalifa, and the ruler of Abu Dhabi on Doha and Al Wakrah in 1867. This led to the Qatari tribes launching an attack on Bahrain in what became known as the Battle of Damssa in 1868, representing a breach of the maritime peace agreements established between Britain and the sheikhdoms of Bahrain and Abu Dhabi.

In response, the British authorities in the Gulf intervened to halt these conflicts, which endangered British interests in the region. The British representative, Colonel Lewis Pelly, advanced with British naval ships to the shores of Qatar, arriving in Al Wakrah in early September 1868, where he met with the leading Qatari sheikhs, including Sheikh Mohammed bin Thani. Pelly expressed his displeasure at their attack on the islands of Bahrain but acknowledged that the British government understood their actions as a retaliatory campaign, which could calm the unrest. Pelly then signed an agreement with Sheikh Mohammed bin Thani on September 12, 1868, which included the following terms:

1. Mohammed bin Thani would reside peacefully in Doha (from which he had withdrawn to the interior of the Qatar Peninsula during the battles).
2. Mohammed bin Thani would refrain from any aggressive actions at sea.
3. Mohammed bin Thani would refer any disputes to the British Resident. If there were disagreements over payments or other issues, they would be submitted to the British Political Resident for resolution. An appendix to the



agreement included a commitment from Sheikh Mohammed bin Thani and the Qatari tribal chiefs to collect an annual sum to be paid through the British Political Resident in exchange for securing protection for Qatar.

Some of the key implications of the Maritime Peace Agreement signed between Qatar and Britain on September 12, 1868, include:

1. **Part of a Series of Maritime Peace Agreements:** The agreement was part of a broader series of general peace and maritime truce agreements that the British government signed with Gulf sheikhdoms. These agreements served as a means for Britain to increase its influence in the region over more than a century and a half.
2. **Recognition of Qatar as an Independent Emirate:** The agreement marked the recognition of Qatar as an independent emirate, not subject to the authority of its neighboring states.
3. **Recognition of Al Thani Rule:** By signing the agreement, there was an implicit recognition of the Al Thani family as the rulers of Qatar, thus officially beginning their rule.
4. **Start of Modern Qatari History:** According to many historians, the agreement represents the beginning of modern Qatari history as an independent emirate, similar to other Gulf emirates.
5. **Beginning of Treaty Relations with Britain:** The agreement marked the start of Qatar's treaty relations with Britain as an external power.